Before I took over the ‘paltan’, I was cautioned by the colonel of the regiment that the subedar major (SM), the highest ranking soldier, was the cause of bad blood between the previous CO and the second-in-command and could be replaced if I wished. I came to know that he was unwanted in the unit also because he was an inductee brought in from another battalion by my predecessor. It was a serious matter and therefore I took my time to decide. I wanted to get on with the task of commanding the battalion rather than being bogged down by an unsavoury event right at the beginning. I had a frank talk with the SM and told him that the battalion could do without him. I didn’t have to remind him that I was commissioned in this very ‘paltan’. The only job I asked him to do was to come up with one good idea for the welfare of the troops every week. He was forbidden to sneak around and do ‘chugli’ or carry tales about others to me. That’s what happens in many units. His acceptability began improving by the day and in due course the issue died down.

After a few months, the battalion was selected for a special mission. In preparing for that task, we were put through a mock exercise in which we were required to locate an insurgent camp in a thick forest and then attack and destroy it. A number of patrols were launched by me to find the target but we remained clueless till the very end. It was like finding a needle in a haystack. Eventually our perseverance paid off. Major P.S. Bhandral’s patrol chanced to locate the suspected camp. The challenge now was to somehow link up with the patrol. I had ordered Major Bhandral to remain in the close vicinity of the target and, if possible, send someone along the ridgeline, where we would marry up. I trusted my map reading, and having plotted the insurgent camp, we set off towards the camp.

On the way we bumped into Havildar Vinayak Thosar, who was sent to guide us to Major Bhandral. It got dark and soon a heavy downpour commenced. We moved very slowly and cautiously, trying to ensure that the long column moving through the dense jungle did not break contact. Sure enough, somewhere a goof-up took place and just before dawn, when we reached the insurgent camp, only half the battalion showed up. The umpire, who was